

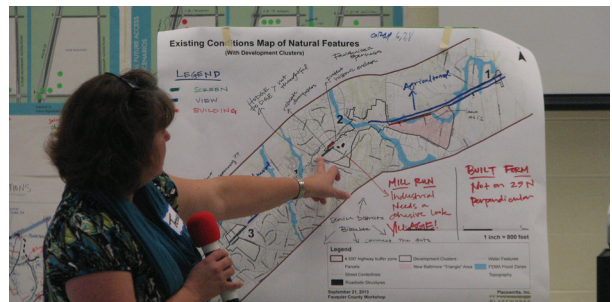
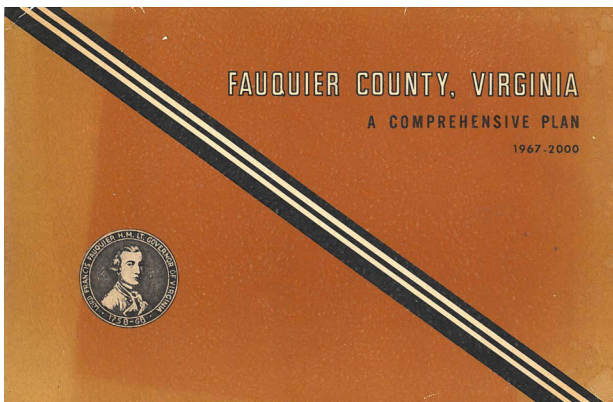




PLANNING AND LAND USE

CHAPTER 1B

Fauquier County Board of Supervisors
Adopted February 12, 2026



I.	Introduction	3
II.	Fauquier County Planning History	4
	The First Planning Commission	4
	The First Comprehensive Plan.....	4
	The 1977-1987 Comprehensive Plan	4
	1981 Rural Land Use Plan Revision and Comprehensive Rezoning.....	5
	The 1987-1997 Comprehensive Plan	5
	The 1992-2010 Comprehensive Plan	5
	1999 Rural Land Use Plan Revision	6
	2000 to Present.....	6
	2015 Chapter 1 Revision.....	6
	2016 Natural and Heritage Resources Chapter Revisions	7
	2019 Rural Land Use Plan Revision	7
	2021 Adoption of Chapter 3B - Housing.....	7
	2026 Revisions to Chapters 4, 5, and 11 and Appendices.....	7
III.	Planning Strategies and Tools	8
IV.	Land Use in Fauquier County	10
	Land Use Plans.....	10
	<i>Rural Lands (Chapter 8)</i>	11
	<i>Villages (Chapter 7)</i>	11
	<i>Service Districts (Chapter 6)</i>	12
V.	Future Planning Considerations	12
	Land Use Needs	12
	Significance of Rural Character and the Rural Economy.....	14
	The Tax Economy.....	14
	Evolving Development Pressure	15
VI.	Implementation / How to Use This Plan	15

I. Introduction

Within the Comprehensive Plan, planning can be grouped into several categories: resource inventory and analysis, land use plans, and infrastructure plans. These categories are divided into chapters that focus on particular aspects of the County's Vision for the future. Taken as a whole, along with other planning tools discussed later this chapter, they work together to provide comprehensive guidance for land use throughout the County.

The resource inventories (Chapters 2A, 2B, 3A, and 3B) provide background information and analysis on the physical characteristics of the County, including its natural and heritage resources, population and demographics, and housing. This information, along with citizen input, has been used to develop Goals, Objectives, and Implementation Actions that support best management and stewardship practices for the County's significant natural and heritage resources and the future land use and housing needs of the County's citizens.

The land use plans translate the Guiding Principles and resource Goals into plans for the physical development of the County. The current land use structure of Fauquier County is remarkably similar to the pattern of development that evolved organically prior to the initiation of intentional planning efforts. Rural lands currently make up over 90 percent of the County, with most of the residential, commercial, and industrial development located in long established settlement areas. The land use plans for these settlement areas, known as Service Districts (Chapter 6) and Villages (Chapter 7), along with the Rural Land Use Plan (Chapter 8) support this pattern by accommodating a careful balance of development and conservation to achieve the County's Vision.

The infrastructure plans include the Public Facilities and Utilities Plan (Chapter 9) and the Transportation Plan (Chapter 10). The purpose of the Public Facilities and Utilities chapter is to plan for future public facility needs, including schools, parks, recreational facilities, libraries, airport, health and human services, and public safety; public utility needs encompassing sewer, water, and solid waste management; and private utilities including electric, gas, and telecommunications. The Transportation chapter sets forth a plan to ensure that the County's transportation systems and infrastructure meet the needs of the planned population and support the Service District, Village, and Rural Land Use Plans. Infrastructure planning is particularly important to the success of the service district concept. Focusing population growth in these more compact settlement areas both assists in the preservation of the County's villages and rural areas and allows the County to provide public services in a more efficient and cost-effective manner.

The land use guidance contained in each chapter of the plan is the result of many years of fine-tuning. For this reason, the County's planning history provides valuable context for the current Comprehensive Plan, a summary of which is included below. This is followed by an introduction to the planning strategies, tools, and land use planning areas that are key to understanding the implementation of the County's Vision, as well as a discussion of future planning considerations.

II. Fauquier County Planning History

While all municipalities are required by the *Code of Virginia* to develop a Comprehensive Plan to guide physical development, Fauquier County is unique in the consistency of its vision over time and the disciplined application of land use policies first formulated in the middle of the last century. This is largely due to the forethought of the citizens, Planning Commissioners, and Board of Supervisors who observed in the very first Comprehensive Plan that while rural, undeveloped communities may not feel the need for formal planning, by the time the community feels the impact of development, planning efforts may have come too late.

The following review of Fauquier County's planning history tracks the evolution of the land use policies that have shaped the physical development of the County to date.

The First Planning Commission

Formal planning in Fauquier County began on December 14, 1950, when the Board of Supervisors appointed the first Planning Commission with instructions to prepare an ordinance and map to "protect the agricultural heritage of the County and to provide for future population growth." The first Subdivision Ordinance was adopted in 1951 and the first significant Zoning Ordinance and Zoning Map were adopted in 1955. The original ordinance and map provided for a predominance of conservation and residential zones with some commercial areas along the highways and near the towns. The residential zones were located on all major highways in the County.

The First Comprehensive Plan

The immense value placed on the rural lands was codified in the late 1960s with the adoption of the first Comprehensive Plan. In it, a population of more than 200,000 by the end of the century was forecast. Alarmed at the prospect of unchecked development on the cherished landscape, the plan's authors designated distinct growth areas, called service districts, leaving the vast majority of the County's land outside of these growth areas, a concept that persists today. Over the next few years, the County adopted a significantly revised Subdivision Ordinance, Zoning Ordinance, and Zoning Map reflecting the recommendations of the Comprehensive Plan. This included an increased amount of conservation zoning, the reintroduction of the agriculture district, and the zoning of service districts. The commercial and industrial areas were zoned as planned; however, the residential land in the service districts was zoned to a holding density of about one dwelling unit per acre until central sewage disposal and water would be available, making development to planned densities feasible.

The 1977-1987 Comprehensive Plan

Over the next decade, the Planning Commission continued the process of refining the Comprehensive Plan with periodic reviews and analysis, including retention of the private firm of Rivkin/Carson to conduct a review of the 1967-2000 plan. Based on public and professional feedback, the Board of Supervisors adopted updated objectives and recognized the need for policy statements related to basic planning, conservation, development guidance, economic growth, and housing. The Board adopted a revised Comprehensive Plan

in 1977 in response to economic and demographic changes in the County. More in-depth land capability analysis of soils, scenic areas, and water-supply potential assisted in the development and adoption of new land use plan chapters for Service Districts, Villages and Settlements, and Resource-Open Lands, which would eventually be renamed the Rural Land Use Plan. These land use plans increased the area of agricultural use, limited the conservation areas to steep, forested land, and reduced the area of the designated service districts. New rural residential, village, and settlement areas were also delineated.

1981 Rural Land Use Plan Revision and Comprehensive Rezoning

The Rural Land Use Plan was revised in 1981, informed by ongoing analysis of population and land use trends. The rural residential areas adopted in 1977 were eliminated to help slow development in rural areas and the agricultural area was increased. Additionally, service district areas were revised. In May of 1981, the County underwent a comprehensive rezoning. The new ordinance redefined the zoning categories and adjusted the relative size of service districts and conservation and agricultural lands in response to the Comprehensive Plan update. The areas devoted to village zoning were also expanded and settlement areas (R-1 zone) were created. Areas for future expansion were shown in the service districts and villages. The resulting configuration of service districts and villages was intended to encourage orderly growth emanating from existing towns and villages.

The 1987-1997 Comprehensive Plan

In 1985, the Planning Commission began a five-year review of the Rural Land Use Plan and discovered an acceleration in the platting of rural subdivisions. At the Board of Supervisor's direction, the Planning Commission undertook an evaluation of the effectiveness of the County's land use plans and regulatory ordinances in directing residential growth away from the rural lands and into the service districts. Recognizing the critical relationship between the preservation of the County's rural areas and the ability to provide adequate services in service district areas, the Board also asked for detailed analysis of the service districts' holding capacity, utility service deficiencies, and the potential cost to upgrade services or expand the districts.

As a result of this analysis, the adopted 1987-1997 Comprehensive Plan included updated Rural Land Use Plan implementation recommendations, more advanced planning of the service districts, and plans for the development of Public Facilities and Utilities and Transportation Plans, both of which were adopted in 1991. Based on recommendations in the updated plan, the Zoning Ordinance was amended to include sliding scale zoning and 85 percent non-common open space requirements in the Agriculture and Conservation zoning districts, as well as an updated definition of Minor Residential Development permitted by-right in each district.

The 1992-2010 Comprehensive Plan

The 1992 five-year review of the 1987-1997 Comprehensive Plan determined that the Plan's planning period should be extended from ten to twenty years to better facilitate planning for public facilities, utilities, and transportation. By providing the longer planning period and a time-phased plan, the County would be able to address the lifecycle costs of public facilities and utilities and evaluate public improvements as a

part of proffered rezonings more effectively. Accordingly, the Planning Commission began an update to the Plan with a particular focus on these strategic planning issues. Following an extensive review and public hearing process, the Board of Supervisors adopted the 1992-2010 Comprehensive Plan in early 1994.

1999 Rural Land Use Plan Revision

Faced with continued development pressure on the County's rural lands, in late 1994 the Board of Supervisors contracted professional planning consulting services "to review and analyze existing rural plans, policies, and implemented ordinances to ensure that they have been and will continue to be effective in carrying out the County's goals and objectives for rural areas." The resulting report, in conjunction with the work of a rural lands steering committee, the Planning Commission, and citizen feedback, became the basis for an amended Rural Land Use Plan adopted in 1999. While in the past the Rural Land Use Plan focused primarily on protecting agricultural land through natural resource protection and the funneling of development to service districts, the 1999 plan emphasized the need to sustain and enhance the agricultural industry. Recommendations included financial incentives, such as the continuation of the Land Use Assessment program and the development of the Purchase of Development Rights (PDR) program, as well as increased coordination with the County's Agricultural Advisory Committee in all matters affecting the agricultural economy. It also emphasized the need to tighten control over all new development in rural areas and provided recommendations intended to mitigate the visual and environmental impact of continued residential development in agricultural areas.

2000 to Present

Since the adoption of the 1992-2010 Comprehensive Plan, subsequent refinements of the Plan have taken place on a chapter-by-chapter basis. As each section of the Plan has progressively become more in-depth and complex over time (and with the issuance of the Plan in a digital format), the County has focused on periodic updates as the need arises rather than re-adopting the Plan as a whole at set planning intervals, as in the past. Each section of the Plan continues to utilize a 20-year planning period. This approach is made possible by the stability of the Comprehensive Plan and efficacy of planning efforts. Rather than requiring complete overhauls every planning period to address runaway development or drastically new conditions, the Comprehensive Plan has effectively evolved with time and maintained its overall integrity. From 2000 to 2015, major revisions to the Comprehensive Plan focused primarily on the refinement of all eight Service District Plans, the Village Plan, and the Public Facilities and Utilities and Transportation Plans, all of which had multiple updates within this time-period. Over the following decade, amendments to each of these sections were adopted as needed. Chapter 3A, which provides population figures and demographic analysis, has also received periodic updates as U.S. Census data is released every ten years.

2015 Chapter 1 Revision

In 2015, the Planning Commission returned its attention to Chapter 1 to reaffirm and update the overall vision and structure of the Comprehensive Plan. A new Chapter 1, titled Introduction and Vision, was adopted by the Board of Supervisors after an extended period of work by the Planning Commission. A major goal of the revision was to provide a consistent form and structure for the Plan as well as introduce a unifying vision for the future of the County. The resulting Vision Statement forms the backbone of the

Comprehensive Plan as it exists today. Further structure was added with four Guiding Principles addressing various aspects of the Vision along with associated Policies to guide implementation. All chapters revised since have included Goals, Objectives, and Implementation Actions that relate back to specific Guiding Principles. This approach ensures the Comprehensive Plan provides the clearest guidance possible while remaining focused on the County's core Vision.

2016 Natural and Heritage Resources Chapter Revisions

In a multi-year process beginning in 2013, Chapter 2: Natural and Heritage Resources also underwent major revisions. While the importance of these resources as key components of the County's prized rural character, along with the agricultural industry, had long been acknowledged in previous versions of the plan, this revision aimed to provide more in-depth inventory and analysis with the addition of specific, actionable resource management Goals, Objectives, and Implementation Actions that had been lacking in the past. Recommendations centered on an integrated approach to resource management, intertwining stewardship and preservation with the County's land planning and economic development goals to the mutual benefit of both. The revised Chapter 2A: Natural Resources and Chapter 2B: Heritage Resources, along with their supporting Appendices, were adopted by the Board of Supervisors in 2016.

2019 Rural Land Use Plan Revision

In 2019, the Board of Supervisors adopted a revised Rural Land Use Plan. The update reaffirmed the County's policies related to preserving farmland, historic sites, and open space in the rural areas of the County but also acknowledged that the success of the rural economy and preservation are interdependent. A new analysis of the rural economy provided guidance related to the agricultural industry, rural tourism, and rural businesses. The revised chapter identified enterprise opportunities for the rural economy consistent with the Vision and character of Fauquier County, as well as suggested policies to guide development and minimize negative impacts on the rural surroundings. As with the Natural and Heritage Resources chapters, Goals, Objectives, and Implementation Actions were introduced to provide clear guidance for land use decisions related to preservation and development in the County's rural lands.

2021 Adoption of Chapter 3B - Housing

Recognizing the need for more comprehensive guidance on housing policy, in 2021 the Board of Supervisors adopted a new chapter on housing. Where in the past planning related to housing was spread throughout the various land use plans, the new chapter provided inventory and analysis related to demand, presence, and affordability of housing on a County-wide basis. It also established Goals, Objectives, and Implementation Actions to help ensure that housing of adequate type, quantity, location, and affordability is provided for all County residents as outlined in the County's Guiding Principle 3 and related Policies.

2026 Revisions to Chapters 4, 5, and 11 and Appendices

In 2025, the Planning Commission began a review of several chapters in the Plan long overdue for updates, including those related to existing Zoning and Land Use, the Economic Base of the County, and Community Design Guidelines, as well as the Appendices to the Plan. The purpose of this review was to ensure that all

parts of the Comprehensive Plan were consistent and continuing to contribute effectively to the function of the overall Plan as a guidance document for future development.

The review found that over time most of the information in these chapters and appendices had been incorporated in more detail in the relevant land use plans, in the demographics section of Chapter 3, or in the case of the Design Guidelines, formalized in the Zoning Ordinance. A major revision was proposed to consolidate remaining relevant information from these portions of the Plan into a new Chapter 1B, which now serves as an introduction to the land use concepts and planning tools utilized by the County in the implementation of its Vision.

III. Planning Strategies and Tools

The success of the planning process requires the development of resource policies, land use plans, and ordinances that reflect the County's Vision. Key to this effort is the understanding and effective use of the planning strategies and tools that have been used to develop and maintain the County's land use policies.

The County's primary land planning strategy is centered on the two main goals of the Comprehensive Plan's Vision Statement: (1) honoring natural and cultural resources, agricultural heritage, and the rural landscape, while (2) building a sustainable economy and promoting outstanding services for citizens. The strategy, which was outlined in the first Comprehensive Plan and forms the backbone of the land use structure described later in this chapter, is to concentrate development into service district areas while facilitating the preservation of rural lands and culture. These two goals are not mutually exclusive, but rather are part of a symbiotic system whereby progress in each area inherently benefits the other. By concentrating the majority of population growth and non-agricultural industrial and commercial uses in service districts, the County is able to promote other planning goals designed to protect the rural areas from unplanned and destructive growth and also provide public services in a more efficient and cost-effective manner. The Guiding Principles identified in Chapter 1A group planning efforts into four distinct areas of focus: natural and cultural resource protection; appropriate community development; a strong and diverse local economy; and effective public facilities and infrastructure. Over time, various advisory and regulatory planning tools have been utilized and gradually refined to achieve a sustainable balance of preservation and development, a strategy that has proved remarkably successful even in the face of strong regional growth pressure.

The Comprehensive Plan is the primary advisory planning tool for the County. This document is a vital tool in understanding and influencing outcomes by providing direction to protect resources and permit orderly development in alignment with the County's Vision. Its purpose is not to regulate, but rather to guide land use, transportation, infrastructure, and resource decisions. Each component of the Comprehensive Plan – resource inventory and analysis, citizen input, land use plans, and infrastructure plans – is an important planning tool and each plays a unique role in the decision-making process. The inventory and analysis of natural, heritage, human, and housing resources is critical for strategic long-term planning. This analysis, along with citizen input, informs and supports the Service District, Village, and Rural Land Use Plans, which establish the desired pattern of land use within each planning area and include basic community design guidelines intended to promote quality development. The land use plans are supported in turn by the Public Facilities and Utilities and Transportation Plans. All of these together form the basis and justification for the County's regulatory planning tools. To remain effective, the Plan must rely on accurate and up-to-date data on the County's resources, its current state of development, and the values and priorities of the

County's citizens. The Comprehensive Plan is a living document that should be updated in response to new information and changing circumstances.

The Zoning Ordinance is the County's primary regulatory planning tool. It translates the Comprehensive Plan's recommendations and land use plans into regulations that govern all aspects of land development in the County. The Zoning Ordinance defines and establishes zoning districts and their boundaries, the uses permitted within each zoning district, and uses which require legislative approval, as well as outlines land use application submission requirements and processes. It also establishes the allowable development densities in each district, open space requirements, and along with the Subdivision Ordinance and Design Standards Manual, provides detailed design and performance regulations. The requirement that certain uses must receive legislative approval on a case-by-case basis is an important feature of the Zoning Ordinance. The legislative review process allows the County to maintain close oversight over the scope and type of development occurring in the County, providing the opportunity to minimize adverse impacts on both citizens and the rural landscape. The County may review requests to change the uses permitted on a particular parcel of land through a rezoning process, with legislative approval on a case-by-case basis. Each rezoning application must demonstrate that the proposed change in use is in compliance with the Comprehensive Plan.

It is important to note that there are varying approaches to zoning, many of which have been included in the Zoning Ordinance over time to achieve more complex or nuanced land planning goals. For instance, sliding scale zoning was instituted to better implement the County's vision for its rural lands. Special and overlay districts have been adopted to add protections where needed, as with the Floodplain Overlay District; to incentivize higher density, mixed-use development with flexible development options in service districts, as with the Mixed-Use Special District – Bealeton Service District, Planned Residential District, and Planned Commercial Industrial Development District; and to promote historic and open space conservation. A mixed-use, form-based code was adopted to govern future development within a portion of the Marshall Service District to ensure future growth is compatible with its historic form. All of these serve to refine planning outcomes and ensure current land use and future development complements the County's Vision and Guiding Principles.

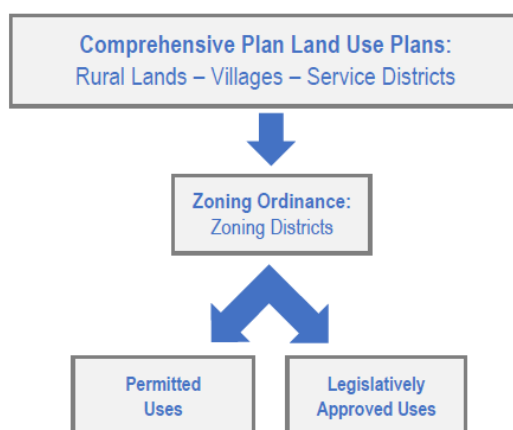
Other planning tools lie outside of the Zoning Ordinance. Programs related to Conservation Easements, Purchase of Development Rights, Agricultural and Forestal Districts, and Land Use Taxation all supplement the County's land planning goals by benefitting the agricultural industry and incentivizing conservation of rural lands. Additionally, fiscal planning can directly influence land use planning efforts. The County's Capital Improvements Program allocates funds for the provision of services, including infrastructure related to schools, public safety, public services, parks and recreation, transportation, and utilities, all of which impact the County's capacity for future development, particularly in the service districts. Economic Development and Tourism efforts work hand-in-hand with land use and preservation goals by fostering business investment that is compatible with the County's Vision.

The purpose of planning is to achieve a policy and regulatory structure that creates a complementary pattern of land use decisions by citizens, businesses, and developers in accordance with the County's Vision. It is important to periodically evaluate the effectiveness of the Comprehensive Plan and the County's regulatory

planning tools at creating the desired pattern of land use. Land use planning is a process, rather than a static achievement, and must adapt to new information and changing circumstances, as clearly demonstrated by the County's planning history.

IV. Land Use in Fauquier County

Current land use in Fauquier County is structured around three distinct planning areas: rural lands, villages, and service districts. The corresponding land use plans in Chapters 6, 7, and 8 provide a template for managed growth for each of these areas in accordance with the County's Vision. This includes establishing development and conservation Goals and Objectives and the identification of suitable locations for the desired balance of land use and infrastructure in each planning area. This land use guidance is translated in the Zoning Ordinance into a unique combination of zoning districts, which assign the specific uses permitted in each area and those that require legislative approval through a Special Permit or Special Exception process.



Zoning districts generally fall into one of several categories of primary use: agriculture, conservation, residential, commercial, or industrial. Complementary uses permitted in these areas must be compatible with the density, size, and character of the primary use. However, in accordance with the Comprehensive Plan, certain mixed-use districts have also been established for villages, mixed commercial/industrial development, planned developments with a full mix of neighborhood scale uses, and for portions of the historic Marshall Service District. These districts encourage types of development other than that normally associated with conventional zoning districts, allowing for potentially higher density development and more integrated, desirable communities in the County's designated settlement areas. The combination of zoning districts assigned within a given planning area facilitate the implementation of the land use guidance contained in the Comprehensive Plan.

Land Use Plans

The land use priorities for the County's rural lands, villages, and service districts are based directly on the Guiding Principles and Policies established in Chapter 1A. It is understood in the development of these land use plans and their supporting fiscal, transportation, and public facility/utility plans that:

1. The County has a variety of physical geographies, each with attributes worth preserving, sensitivities to development, and areas suitable for particular types of development; and that
2. Areas suitable for development should be delineated and planned according to general County need, ability to provide services, and the character of the area; and that
3. Development that burdens the taxpayer and is destructive to the environment and/or character of the County should be minimized.

The plans provide a framework for future development by allocating land suitable for conservation or agricultural, residential, commercial, industrial, and/or mixed use, depending on local context. The following summaries provide an overview of each planning area with examples of the zoning districts commonly utilized in the implementation of the land use plans. Please refer to the discussion of planning strategies and tools for more information on the relationship between the Comprehensive Plan and the Zoning Ordinance.

Rural Lands (Chapter 8)

The County's Vision for its rural lands focuses primarily on protecting and preserving farmland, natural and scenic resources, historic sites, and open space. Rural lands cover over 90 percent of the County and consist primarily of open agricultural lands, wooded mountains, and areas of steep slope. Rural lands are intended predominately for agricultural, silvicultural, or open space uses with limited, low-density residential and low-impact commercial and industrial uses that do not conflict with the agricultural, forestal, or environmentally sensitive areas of the County. Other uses permitted with legislative approval include activities related to rural tourism and low-impact rural businesses. All development in rural areas must be compatible with the County's existing rural character. The far majority of the rural lands are zoned either Agriculture (RA) or Conservation (RC), with a limited amount of low-density Residential zoning (R-1, RR-2), and a few isolated areas of Commercial Highway (C-2) and Industrial (I-1, I-2) zoning.

Villages (Chapter 7)

Villages have long been a part of the rural fabric of the County, serving as social and economic hubs for the surrounding countryside. Locations with a village designation, most of which are historic settlements, are designed to have limited and smaller scale mixtures of residential, commercial, and service land uses based on their historic role as a part of the rural landscape and agricultural economy of Fauquier County. As with service districts, villages are intended to maintain defined edges to help prevent increasing density from threatening adjacent rural lands as well as to preserve their historic character. The adaptive reuse of existing structures is encouraged for residential and commercial development, along with careful infill of vacant properties. Any new development in and around the villages must be designed to be visually compatible with existing street patterns and design, building footprints, and setbacks in each community. Villages may include a combination of Village (V) and Commercial Village (CV) zoning, and/or a limited amount of low-density Residential (R-1, RR-2), Commercial (C-1, C-2) and Industrial (I-1, I-2) zoning depending on the scale and history of the village.

Service Districts (Chapter 6)

Service districts are the County's growth areas and are designed to accommodate the highest density residential, commercial, and industrial uses in the County. Fauquier County has eight service districts, all of which are located adjacent to major transportation corridors. These include the Catlett, Midland, Opal, Bealeton, and Remington Service Districts located in the southern portion of the County; the Warrenton and New Baltimore Service Districts in the center of the County; and the Marshall Service District to the north. These planning areas are distinct from the surrounding rural lands and from the three incorporated towns in the County: Warrenton, Remington, and The Plains, which are responsible for planning land use within their boundaries. The planned development for service districts ranges in scale from the primarily non-residentially focused districts of Opal and Midland, to a village-scale mix of uses in Catlett, up to the more intensely planned districts. Each service district plan defines and locates its boundaries and key features, such as floodplain, parks, roads, schools, streams, and railway lines, as well as the desired scale and mix of development.

To accommodate more intensive growth and density, service districts are either currently served with public utilities or planned for future provision of public utilities in the form of public sewer, water, or both. While all service districts in the County share the role of designated development areas, each represents a unique community informed by its location, resources, and history. Each service district plan includes a future land use map that designates the intended location and density of uses within the district, including residential, commercial, industrial, or mixed use. Zoning within service districts may include Residential districts with a range of density (R-1 through R-4, Townhouses, and Garden Apartments), both Neighborhood and Highway Commercial districts (C-1 and C-2), and Business Park and Industrial districts (BP, I-1, and I-2), as well as certain mixed-use districts (PDMU, PCID, MU-Bealeton, and the Marshall Code).

V. Future Planning Considerations

Land use planning is a complex undertaking that must account not only for the physical designations associated with land use but also related policies that influence patterns of development. As stated earlier, the goal is to achieve a regulatory and policy structure that creates a complementary pattern of land use decisions by citizens, businesses, and developers. In Fauquier County, this pattern is rooted in the County's primary land planning strategy, which depends on both appropriate service district growth and a strong rural economy to support the preservation of rural lands and culture. There are several considerations which directly impact planning in these areas.

Land Use Needs

Effective planning requires careful attention to the County's future land use needs. To remain in alignment with the County's Vision, the land use demands associated with population growth must be balanced with the future availability of service district infrastructure as well as with the needs of existing citizens and the County's natural resource, heritage resource, and rural conservation priorities. The goal is to designate adequate space for anticipated residential, commercial, and industrial uses, while protecting rural uses within the context of the County's established land use structure.

As a starting point, growth formulas are typically applied to projected population numbers to provide an estimated demand for each type of land use. Estimated demand can be determined for the County as a whole, as well as for individual service districts, villages, and rural areas based on local trends. Within the context of the priorities established by the Comprehensive Plan, future land use can then be assigned based on the unique circumstances in each planned area. This requires careful analysis of the compatibility of uses within each land use plan, as well as the balance of designated uses within the County as a whole. It is important to note that future development is subject to a range of factors, from changing demographics to the national and local economies, and does not always occur along a predictable timeline. However, by proactively planning for expected growth, the County can guide future development in ways that best serves the County's Vision and the practical needs of its citizens.

In the case of future residential land use needs, the projected population is typically divided by the County's average household size to determine the number of additional dwelling units that may be required over the next 20-year planning period. The type, proportion, and density of future residential land use areas can then be allocated as needed. This should take into account compatibility with existing communities, the full range of housing needs of the County's population (outlined in Chapter 3), the availability of current and future service district infrastructure, and the potential impact on the County's tax base.

Commercial land use needs are most closely related to population density. The amount of commercial activity in an area is also heavily influenced by the overall market economy and the market for a particular commercial use. As the population grows, it creates an increased demand for commercial retail and commercial service businesses as well as expands the potential employment pool, which in turn helps to attract new commercial enterprises. From a planning perspective, the locations and types of future commercial land use designations are just as important as the amount provided. Village and neighborhood-scale commercial uses may increase the livability of the County's residential communities, while larger scale and regional commercial uses located on transportation corridors may provide services and potential employment opportunities for County residents. Other types of commercial uses, such as non-retail administrative, business, and professional offices, are typically lower impact and therefore more compatible with a range of other uses, in addition to being valuable employers for County residents.

While projected residential and commercial land use needs are directly tethered to population growth within the County, the same cannot be assumed for future industrial land use needs. Demand for industrial land use is more closely related to regional and even national economic trends. Given this fact, the planning motivation to designate land for future industrial use is more related to a desire to boost the tax base of the County than to population growth. The challenge in Fauquier County is that most of the undeveloped industrial land is not presently served by public utilities or has other impediments to development, such as restrictions related to the flood plain, transportation concerns, or future utility availability. When designating additional land for future industrial uses, careful analysis will be necessary to provide usable land in locations compatible both with existing development and with the County's rural priorities.

In the context of the County's current planning efforts, future residential, commercial, and industrial land use designations typically mean that a certain amount of undeveloped land has been allocated to accommodate growth. However, as the County's service districts get closer to build-out capacity in the future, it will be critical to plan for strategic re-development of land at higher densities or the appropriate re-use of existing facilities.

It is also important to note that not all future land use needs are related to growth. Guiding Principle A of this Plan identifies both agricultural and silvicultural lands and natural and heritage resources as intrinsic to the County's character and worthy of preservation. In addition to their contributions to the County's rural character and lifestyle, these land uses and resources provide documented economic and ecological benefits to the County and should be considered on equal footing with other land use needs.

Significance of Rural Character and the Rural Economy

Preservation of the County's rural character has remained a priority since the adoption of the first Comprehensive Plan in the 1960's. Rural culture has long been integral to the County's collective identity and a major contributor to quality of life in the County. The most obvious preservation strategy is to adopt policies that promote the conservation of rural lands. However, as evidenced by the County's evolving rural land planning strategies, conservation efforts alone are not enough. To successfully achieve this goal, it is important to recognize the link between the County's rural character and the rural economy.

It is no coincidence that the County's agricultural industry, which has historically been the largest contributor to the rural economy, is also largely responsible for the prized physical characteristics of the County's rural landscape. The two are intrinsically linked and function together to create rural character. The best way to maintain the County's rural character is to ensure a continued demand for rural lands by fostering a robust rural economy. However, as traditional agriculture, which was taken as a given in the past, experiences increasing economic challenges, the maintenance of rural character requires extra focus and intentional, targeted strategies to bolster a more diverse rural economy. This takes a multi-faceted approach that encourages the voluntary conservation of rural land while at the same time promoting policies intended to boost the rural economy so that the land will continue to be used for agriculture and other compatible rural activities, such as tourism and rural businesses. Without this, the regional development pressure that contributes to service district growth is likely to spill over into rural areas of the County. Just as the service district concept has been sustained by regional development pressure, the viability of rural lands must be sustained by the rural economy.

The Tax Economy

The relationship between land use planning and the tax economy is also an important consideration. The County's property tax revenue is closely related to the composition of the tax base, which is subject to influence by local land use policies, particularly the planned mix of residential, commercial, and industrial uses. As property taxes represent the largest local source of revenue and are used to fund infrastructure improvements and the public service demands that accompany both existing and new development, it is prudent to consider the tax implications of the County's land planning efforts.

Not all land uses generate sufficient taxes to cover their share of infrastructure and service costs. For this reason, it is important to balance high service uses, such as the typical single-family home, with other types of development that can positively impact the County's tax base, such as commercial and industrial development. Given the County's traditionally low unemployment rates, higher impact and labor-intensive industrial development may not be appropriate. The demand for workers would likely contribute to an increase in residents that may pay less in taxes than they would require in services, offsetting the direct tax base benefit of the industry.

The challenge is to plan for growth in the County's service districts that both serves the larger Vision and is fiscally sustainable. Adequate funding for the services and infrastructure that make service districts appealing for future development is key for the long-term success of the County's Vision. It helps create quality, livable communities that are complemented by the County's prized rural character.

Evolving Development Pressure

For many years, the County's primary planning strategy, centered on service district growth and a strong rural economy, has relied on relatively predictable residential, commercial, and industrial land use demands. However, evolving development pressure, particularly that related to rapidly changing technology and energy demand, has recently created new planning challenges. When requests for uses that lie outside the current parameters of the Comprehensive Plan and Zoning Ordinance arise, it is critical to identify and proactively respond to these emerging land uses to determine their possible compatibility with the County's Vision and impact on the health, safety, and welfare of the County's citizens.

Although the planning process can sometimes be complicated by limited data on the potential impacts of new types of development, a systematic approach that carefully considers the Comprehensive Plan and its existing development and resource policies; takes into account citizen input; and is informed by the experiences of other jurisdictions with similar development will ensure that the County meets planning challenges as they emerge. Should a use be deemed appropriate, standards can be developed and adopted in a timely manner to mitigate any potential negative impacts. If it is determined that a new use is not in keeping with the County's Vision, the impact of undesirable development can be averted. As noted in the first Comprehensive Plan, by the time the community feels the impact of development, planning efforts may have come too late. A proactive approach that responds to evolving development pressure with informed policies and standards ensures that the County's planning efforts remain relevant over time.

VI. Implementation / How to Use This Plan

The success of the Comprehensive Plan depends directly on how effectively it is implemented. This requires a disciplined application of the Policies, Goals, Objectives, and Implementation Actions throughout the Plan in all decisions related to land use. The Comprehensive Plan provides the basis for the Zoning Ordinance and other land planning tools adopted by the County and is the document by which the County evaluates special use and rezoning applications, public facility locations, and capital improvements for consistency with its development policies. Chapters 2 through 5 should be consulted for conservation and development goals related to the County's resources; Chapters 6 through 8 for specific guidance on future land use in each of the County's planning areas; and Chapters 9 and 10 for information on public facility, utility, and transportation plans for the County. Although divided by topic, the land use guidance found in each chapter is intended to work in concert to achieve the County's development and conservation goals. All future land use decisions should take into account guidance from all relevant chapters of the Plan.